US PARATROOPER EQUIPMENT

US Airborne soldiers used much of the standard equipment of a World War II US infantryman, although with a bias towards items that were light and easily portable. K-rations, ideal for men who might have to survive behind enemy lines without resupply, were first tested by Airborne troops in 1942 before becoming general army issue. They could be supplemented by energy-rich D-rations. The M3 fighting knife, for hand-to-hand fighting, was mass produced from 1943.

M36 musette bag and rope
Adopted by paratroopers for its versatility, the musette bag would have held ammunition, rations, and personal effects. The rope was included in case the soldier needed to free himself from a tree or building.

Rope 10m (33ft) in length

Standard issue raincoat folded under flap

Fore sight

Gas cylinder

M2 switchblade
The soldier used the knife to cut himself free of his webbing.

M1A1 Garand rifle and ammunition
The Garand was the standard US Army rifle of World War II. A semi-automatic, it was loaded by inserting an 8-round spring steel clip into the empty magazine. The empty clip was automatically ejected after the last round was fired. Soldiers had to watch out for the bolt snapping shut while reloading, or risk a case of "M1 thumb". The M1A1 carbine was also specific to the Airborne.

First aid kit

M1928 cartridge belt with webbing
Spray painted with camouflage paint, the cartridge belt had enough pouches to hold 80 rounds for the M1 rifle.

One of ten pockets, each holding an 8-round clip for the M1 rifle

M3 FIGHTING KNIFE

Strap for attaching to lower leg

M1 knife bayonet

Entrenching tool – a collapsible shovel

M1910 canteen

M1910 first-aid kit